FirstOffer

DATA ANALYST INTERVIEW KIT · TOOLS & STATS

20 Excel, Statistics & Power BI Questions for Data Analysts

The tool and statistics questions that come up in almost every analyst interview — lookups, pivots, averages vs medians, p-values, A/B tests and DAX basics — with short answers you can say out loud.

Excel formulas | Pivot tables | Statistics | A/B testing | Power BI & DAX

20 questions

20 tested examples

4 topics

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Written from the interviewer's side · Easy → Medium

START HERE

How to use this kit

1
Read the question and answer it out loud before you look at the model answer.

2
Read “What the interviewer is checking” — that's what you're actually scored on.

3
Run the code yourself, change one thing, and predict the new output before running it again.

SPOT THE CLUE

If the question says… reach for…

“Bring a value from another table”	**XLOOKUP · INDEX + MATCH · VLOOKUP(..., FALSE)**
“Total / count with conditions”	**SUMIFS · COUNTIFS · AVERAGEIFS**
“Summarise by category, fast”	**Pivot table**
“Typical value with outliers”	**Median, not mean**
“Is this difference real?”	**Hypothesis test · p-value · A/B test**
“Does X cause Y?”	**Correlation ≠ causation — look for an experiment**
“A number that reacts to slicers”	**DAX measure (not a calculated column)**
“Clean and shape before modelling”	**Power Query, then a star schema**

IN THE INTERVIEW ROOM

1 · Clarify the business question **2 · Name the formula / test** **3 · Say why it fits**
4 · Mention one pitfall **5 · Tie it to a decision**

SAMPLE DATA

The data used in this kit

Excel questions use this **Sales** sheet (A1:E9). Every formula result shown was recalculated in a real spreadsheet engine.

Sales sheet

	A	B	C	D	E
1	Order	Customer	City	Category	Amount
2	1	Ravi	Bengaluru	Electronics	1200
3	2	Neha	Pune	Books	800
4	3	Ravi	Bengaluru	Books	1500
5	4	Imran	Delhi	Grocery	400
6	5	Ravi	Bengaluru	Electronics	700
7	6	Pooja	Bengaluru	Electronics	2200
8	7	Neha	Pune	Books	950
9	8	Imran	Delhi	Grocery	400

CONTENTS

20 questions, easy to medium

Excel essentials

01	VLOOKUP vs INDEX-MATCH vs XLOOKUP — which do you use?	Easy
02	Total sales for Bengaluru Electronics only. Which formula?	Easy
03	What is a pivot table and when would you use it?	Easy
04	What's the difference between A1, A1, $A1 and A$1?	Easy
05	How do you write nested conditions and hide errors cleanly?	Easy
06	How do you clean messy data in Excel?	Easy

Statistics every analyst needs

07	Mean vs median vs mode — which would you report for salaries?	Easy
08	What does standard deviation tell you?	Easy
09	What is a normal distribution? What's the 68–95–99.7 rule?	Easy
10	How do you find outliers, and what do you do with them?	Medium
11	Correlation vs causation — explain with an example.	Easy

Testing & experiments

12	Explain a p-value to a non-technical manager.	Medium
13	What are Type I and Type II errors?	Easy
14	How would you design an A/B test for a new 'Apply' button?	Medium
15	What is sampling bias? Give an example.	Easy

Power BI & DAX

16	Measure vs calculated column in Power BI?	Easy
17	What does CALCULATE do? What is filter context?	Medium
18	What is a star schema and why does Power BI prefer it?	Medium
19	Power Query vs DAX — what goes where?	Easy
20	Which chart would you use for what? How do you design a dashboard?	Easy

Excel essentials

01 VLOOKUP vs INDEX-MATCH vs XLOOKUP — which do you use?

Excel · Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

Whether you know VLOOKUP's limits and the better alternatives.

MODEL ANSWER

- VLOOKUP searches the first column and returns a column to the right; it breaks if columns are inserted. Always use FALSE for an exact match.
- INDEX-MATCH can look left and doesn't break when columns move.
- XLOOKUP (Excel 2021 / 365) does both, has a built-in 'not found' value, and is the cleanest choice.

FORMULA	WHAT IT DOES	RESULT
`=VLOOKUP(6, A2:E9, 5, FALSE)`	Amount of order 6	**2200**
`=INDEX(B2:B9, MATCH(2200, E2:E9, 0))`	Who placed the ₹2,200 order (looks left)	**Pooja**
`=XLOOKUP(10, A2:A9, E2:E9, "Not found")`	Order 10 doesn't exist	**Not found**

✓ RESULTS RECALCULATED IN A SPREADSHEET ENGINE ON THE SALES SHEET

Common mistake Leaving VLOOKUP's last argument empty — it defaults to approximate match and returns wrong values.

Interviewer may ask next Which one returns the FIRST match when there are duplicates? (All of them, by default.)

02 Total sales for Bengaluru Electronics only. Which formula?

Excel Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

Conditional aggregation — used daily in reporting.

MODEL ANSWER

- SUMIFS(sum_range, criteria_range1, criteria1, criteria_range2, criteria2, ...) — all conditions must be true.
- COUNTIFS and AVERAGEIFS follow the same pattern.
- Criteria can use operators in quotes, like ">1000".

FORMULA	WHAT IT DOES	RESULT
`=SUMIFS(E2:E9, C2:C9, "Bengaluru", D2:D9, "Electronics")`	Bengaluru Electronics revenue	**4100**
`=COUNTIFS(E2:E9, ">1000")`	Orders above ₹1,000	**3**
`=AVERAGEIFS(E2:E9, B2:B9, "Neha")`	Neha's average order	**875**

✓ RESULTS RECALCULATED IN A SPREADSHEET ENGINE ON THE SALES SHEET

Common mistake Mixing up the argument order — SUMIF puts the sum range LAST, SUMIFS puts it FIRST.

Interviewer may ask next How would you do an OR condition (Pune or Delhi)? (Add two SUMIFS together, or use SUM(SUMIFS(..., {"Pune","Delhi"})).)

03 What is a pivot table and when would you use it?

Excel Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

That you can summarise data quickly without writing formulas.

MODEL ANSWER

- A pivot table summarises a big table by dragging fields into Rows, Columns, Values and Filters.
- Use it for quick questions like revenue by city and category, or order count by month.
- Values can show Sum, Count, Average or '% of total'; dates can be grouped by month/quarter.
- Format the source as a Table (Ctrl+T) so the pivot picks up new rows on Refresh.

PYTHON

```
# What a City × Category pivot of the Sales sheet shows
df = pd.DataFrame({"City":
["Bengaluru","Pune","Bengaluru","Delhi","Bengaluru","Bengaluru","Pune","Delhi"],
                   "Category":
["Electronics","Books","Books","Grocery","Electronics","Electronics","Books","Grocery"],
                   "Amount": [1200, 800, 1500, 400, 700, 2200, 950, 400]})
print(df.pivot_table(index="City", columns="Category", values="Amount",
                     aggfunc="sum", fill_value=0, margins=True, margins_name="Total"))
```

OUTPUT ✓ REAL RUN

```
Category   Books  Electronics  Grocery  Total
City
Bengaluru   1500         4100        0   5600
Delhi          0            0      800    800
Pune        1750            0        0   1750
Total       3250         4100      800   8150
```

Common mistake Forgetting to Refresh after the source data changes — pivots don't update automatically.

Interviewer may ask next What's a slicer? (A clickable filter button for pivots and charts.)

04 What's the difference between A1, A1, $A1 and A$1?

Excel Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

Absolute vs relative references — a very common screening question.

MODEL ANSWER

- A1 (relative): both column and row shift when you copy the formula.
- A1 (absolute): nothing shifts — use it for a fixed cell like a tax rate.
- $A1 locks the column only; A$1 locks the row only (mixed references).
- Press F4 while editing to cycle through the four types.

FORMULA	WHAT IT DOES	RESULT
`=E2*$G$1`	Amount × GST rate in G1 (G1 = 0.18) — copy down and G1 stays fixed	**216**

✓ RESULTS RECALCULATED IN A SPREADSHEET ENGINE ON THE SALES SHEET

Common mistake Copying =E2*G1 down the column — it becomes E3*G2, E4*G3 … and the results are wrong.

Interviewer may ask next When would you use a named range instead? (Readability: =E2*GST_Rate.)

05 How do you write nested conditions and hide errors cleanly?

Excel Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

IF / IFS for logic and IFERROR for clean reports.

MODEL ANSWER

- IF(test, value_if_true, value_if_false); IFS checks several conditions in order (Excel 2019+).
- IFERROR(formula, fallback) replaces #N/A, #DIV/0! etc. with your fallback value.
- Use IFERROR carefully — it can hide real mistakes. IFNA only catches #N/A.

FORMULA	WHAT IT DOES	RESULT
`=IFS(E7>=1500, "Gold", E7>=800, "Silver", TRUE, "Bronze")`	Band for order 6 (₹2,200)	**Gold**
`=IF(E5>=800, "Silver", "Bronze")`	Band for order 4 (₹400)	**Bronze**
`=IFERROR(E2/0, 0)`	Division by zero shown as 0	**0**

✓ RESULTS RECALCULATED IN A SPREADSHEET ENGINE ON THE SALES SHEET

Common mistake Wrapping every formula in IFERROR so broken lookups quietly show 0.

Interviewer may ask next What do #N/A, #VALUE! and #REF! each mean?

06 How do you clean messy data in Excel?

Excel Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

A practical checklist, not just one function.

MODEL ANSWER

- TRIM removes extra spaces; PROPER / UPPER / LOWER fix case; CLEAN removes non-printing characters.
- Data → Remove Duplicates; Text to Columns (or TEXTSPLIT) splits values.
- Find & Replace for known variants; VALUE / DATEVALUE turn text into numbers or dates.
- For repeatable cleaning, use Power Query so the steps re-run on new data.

FORMULA	WHAT IT DOES	RESULT
`=PROPER(TRIM(" ravi kumar "))`	Clean a messy name	**Ravi Kumar**
`=VALUE("1,200")`	Text number → real number	**1200**

✔ RESULTS RECALCULATED IN A SPREADSHEET ENGINE ON THE SALES SHEET

Common mistake Cleaning by hand cell by cell — not repeatable when next month's file arrives.

Interviewer may ask next How do you spot numbers stored as text? (Left-aligned, green triangle, ISTEXT.)

07 Mean vs median vs mode — which would you report for salaries?

Statistics · Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

That you know the mean is pulled by outliers.

MODEL ANSWER

- Mean = sum ÷ count; median = the middle value; mode = the most frequent value.
- Salaries are skewed — a few very high values pull the mean up — so the median shows the 'typical' salary better.
- Report both when it matters: a big gap between them is itself a finding.

PYTHON

```
salaries = pd.Series([4.5, 5, 5, 6, 6.5, 7, 45])   # LPA; one senior hire
print("mean  :", round(salaries.mean(), 2))
print("median:", salaries.median())
print("mode  :", salaries.mode().tolist())
```

OUTPUT ✓ REAL RUN

```
mean  : 11.29
median: 6.0
mode  : [5.0]
```

Common mistake Saying 'the average fresher here earns about 11 LPA' when 6 of 7 people earn 7 LPA or less.

Interviewer may ask next Which measure works for categories like city? (Only the mode.)

08 What does standard deviation tell you?

Statistics Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

An intuitive explanation of spread.

MODEL ANSWER

- It measures how spread out values are around the mean — small SD means values are close together.
- Variance is SD squared (harder to read because its units are squared).
- Two products can have the same average daily sales but very different SDs — one is predictable, one isn't.

PYTHON

```
steady = pd.Series([100, 102, 98, 101, 99])
spiky  = pd.Series([40, 160, 70, 150, 80])
print("means:", steady.mean(), spiky.mean())
print("std  :", round(steady.std(), 1), round(spiky.std(), 1))
```

OUTPUT ✓ REAL RUN

```
means: 100.0 100.0
std  : 1.6 52.4
```

Common mistake Comparing SDs of things measured on very different scales — use the coefficient of variation (SD ÷ mean).

Interviewer may ask next Sample SD vs population SD? (Sample divides by n − 1; Excel STDEV.S vs STDEV.P.)

09 What is a normal distribution? What's the 68–95–99.7 rule?

Statistics Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

Basic distribution vocabulary.

MODEL ANSWER

- A symmetric bell-shaped curve where mean = median = mode.
- About 68% of values fall within 1 SD of the mean, 95% within 2 SD, 99.7% within 3 SD.
- So a value more than 3 SD away is very unusual — a common outlier rule (z-score > 3).
- Many real metrics are skewed instead (income, order value), so check with a histogram first.

PYTHON

```
rng = np.random.default_rng(7)
x = rng.normal(loc=50, scale=10, size=100_000)
for k in (1, 2, 3):
    print(f"within {k} SD: {np.mean(np.abs(x - 50) < k * 10):.1%}")
```

OUTPUT ✓ REAL RUN

```
within 1 SD: 68.3%
within 2 SD: 95.4%
within 3 SD: 99.8%
```

Common mistake Assuming every dataset is normal and applying z-score rules to heavily skewed data.

Interviewer may ask next What is skewness? Is income left- or right-skewed? (Right-skewed: long tail of high values.)

10 How do you find outliers, and what do you do with them?

Statistics · Medium

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

A method AND a judgement about what to do next.

MODEL ANSWER

- IQR method: anything below Q1 − 1.5×IQR or above Q3 + 1.5×IQR (what a box plot shows).
- Z-score method: |z| > 3, for roughly normal data.
- Then investigate: a typo → fix or remove; a genuine big customer → keep it and maybe report it separately.

PYTHON

```
orders = pd.Series([1200, 800, 1500, 400, 700, 2200, 950, 400, 15000])
q1, q3 = orders.quantile([0.25, 0.75])
iqr = q3 - q1
print("Q1, Q3, IQR:", q1, q3, iqr)
print("upper fence:", q3 + 1.5 * iqr)
print("outliers:", orders[orders > q3 + 1.5 * iqr].tolist())
```

OUTPUT ✓ REAL RUN

```
Q1, Q3, IQR: 700.0 1500.0 800.0
upper fence: 2700.0
outliers: [15000]
```

Common mistake Deleting outliers just to make a chart look nicer.

Interviewer may ask next Excel version? (QUARTILE.INC for Q1/Q3, then a COUNTIFS on the fences.)

11 Correlation vs causation — explain with an example.

Statistics Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

Critical thinking, not just a definition.

MODEL ANSWER

- Correlation: two things move together. Causation: one actually makes the other happen.
- Ice-cream sales and AC sales are correlated — both are driven by hot weather (a confounder).
- To show causation, you need an experiment (A/B test) or careful methods that control for confounders.
- Correlation (r) runs from −1 to +1 and only measures LINEAR relationships.

PYTHON

```
temp      = np.array([24, 27, 30, 33, 36, 38])
ice_cream = np.array([120, 165, 180, 250, 270, 320])
ac_sales  = np.array([12, 13, 21, 24, 33, 34])
print("r =", round(np.corrcoef(ice_cream, ac_sales)[0, 1], 3))
```

OUTPUT ✓ REAL RUN

```
r = 0.949
```

Common mistake Telling a manager 'feature X increased sales' when you only saw both go up in the same month.

Interviewer may ask next Can two variables have r ≈ 0 but still be strongly related? (Yes — a U-shaped relationship.)

Testing & experiments

12 Explain a p-value to a non-technical manager.

Hypothesis testing · Medium

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

A correct, simple explanation — this is where many candidates go wrong.

MODEL ANSWER

- We start by assuming 'there's no real difference' (the null hypothesis).
- The p-value is the probability of seeing a difference at least this big just by random chance, IF that assumption were true.
- Small p (commonly < 0.05) → the result would be surprising under 'no difference', so we reject the null.
- It is NOT the probability that the null hypothesis is true, and it doesn't measure how big the effect is.

PYTHON

```
from scipy import stats
old_page = [12, 15, 11, 14, 13, 12, 16, 13]   # minutes on page
new_page = [16, 18, 15, 17, 19, 16, 18, 17]
t, p = stats.ttest_ind(new_page, old_page)
print(f"t = {t:.2f}, p = {p:.5f}")
```

OUTPUT ✓ REAL RUN

```
t = 5.00, p = 0.00019
```

Common mistake Saying 'p = 0.03 means there's a 97% chance our change works.'

Interviewer may ask next Statistically significant vs practically significant? (A tiny effect can be 'significant' with huge data but not worth acting on.)

13 What are Type I and Type II errors?

Hypothesis testing · Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

Understanding the trade-off between false alarms and missed effects.

MODEL ANSWER

- Type I (false positive): you conclude there IS an effect when there isn't. Its rate is α (often 5%).
- Type II (false negative): you miss a real effect. Power = 1 − P(Type II).
- Example: a spam filter that blocks a real email = Type I; one that lets spam through = Type II.
- Bigger samples reduce Type II errors without increasing Type I.

Common mistake Mixing up which is which — remember: Type I = 'false alarm'.

Interviewer may ask next In a medical test, which error is worse? (Usually a false negative — the disease is missed.)

14 How would you design an A/B test for a new 'Apply' button?

Experiments Medium

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

A clear, end-to-end process — a favourite product-analyst question.

MODEL ANSWER

- 1. Define one primary metric (e.g. apply-click rate) and a hypothesis.
- 2. Randomly split users into A (old button) and B (new) — same time period.
- 3. Decide the sample size / duration up front; don't stop the test the moment it looks good.
- 4. Compare with a suitable test (two-proportion z-test for rates) and check guardrail metrics.
- 5. Recommend: ship, don't ship, or test again — with the effect size, not just the p-value.

PYTHON

```
from scipy.stats import norm
clicks   = np.array([460, 520])        # A, B
visitors = np.array([5000, 5000])
rate = clicks / visitors
pooled = clicks.sum() / visitors.sum()
se = np.sqrt(pooled * (1 - pooled) * (1 / visitors[0] + 1 / visitors[1]))
z = (rate[1] - rate[0]) / se
p = 2 * (1 - norm.cdf(abs(z)))         # two-sided
print(f"A: {rate[0]:.1%}  B: {rate[1]:.1%}  z = {z:.2f}  p = {p:.3f}")
```

OUTPUT ✓ REAL RUN

```
A: 9.2%  B: 10.4%  z = 2.02  p = 0.044
```

Common mistake 'Peeking' every day and stopping as soon as p < 0.05 — this inflates false positives.

Interviewer may ask next What if the test shows B wins on clicks but completed applications drop? (Check guardrails; clicks alone aren't the goal.)

15 What is sampling bias? Give an example.

Experiments Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

Awareness that WHO is in your data affects the conclusion.

MODEL ANSWER

- It happens when the sample doesn't represent the population you want to make claims about.
- Example: surveying only users who opened the app this week about 'why users leave' — the people who left are missing.
- Survivorship bias is a common type: you only see the cases that 'survived'.
- Fixes: random sampling, stratified sampling, or clearly limiting the claim to who was sampled.

Common mistake Using an online poll of your followers to estimate the whole country's opinion.

Interviewer may ask next Random vs stratified sampling? (Stratified samples each group — e.g. each city — in proportion.)

16 Measure vs calculated column in Power BI?

Power BI · Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

The most common Power BI interview question.

MODEL ANSWER

- Calculated column: computed row by row when data refreshes, stored in the table, uses memory. Good for categories you want to slice by.
- Measure: computed on the fly for whatever filters are active (slicers, visuals). Not stored. Use it for totals, ratios and KPIs.
- Rule of thumb: if you'd put it on an axis or slicer → column; if you'd aggregate it → measure.

```dax
-- Calculated column (row by row, stored)
Order Size = IF(Sales[Amount] >= 1000, "Large", "Small")

-- Measures (react to filters)
Total Sales   = SUM(Sales[Amount])
Order Count   = COUNTROWS(Sales)
Avg Order     = DIVIDE([Total Sales], [Order Count])
```

Common mistake Creating a calculated column for 'Total Sales' — it repeats the grand total on every row.

Interviewer may ask next Why use DIVIDE instead of '/'? (It handles divide-by-zero safely.)

17 What does CALCULATE do? What is filter context?

DAX · Medium

> **WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING**
> The core concept behind most DAX.

MODEL ANSWER

- Filter context = the filters active on a visual (slicer selections, the row/column of a matrix).
- CALCULATE evaluates an expression after changing that filter context — adding, replacing or removing filters.
- ALL() removes filters — handy for '% of total'.

```dax
Bengaluru Sales = CALCULATE([Total Sales], Sales[City] = "Bengaluru")

All-City Sales  = CALCULATE([Total Sales], ALL(Sales[City]))

% of All Cities = DIVIDE([Total Sales], [All-City Sales])
```

Common mistake Using FILTER(Sales, ...) over a whole big table when a simple column filter works — much slower.

Interviewer may ask next SUM vs SUMX? (SUMX iterates row by row, e.g. SUMX(Sales, Sales[Qty] * Sales[Price]).)

18 What is a star schema and why does Power BI prefer it?

Data modelling · Medium

> **WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING**
> Basic data modelling — facts vs dimensions.

MODEL ANSWER

- Fact table in the middle: one row per event (order, click) with numbers and keys.
- Dimension tables around it: descriptions (Customer, Product, Date, City).
- One-to-many relationships from each dimension to the fact table, with filters flowing from dimension to fact.
- It's simpler, faster and makes DAX easier than one giant flat table or a tangled web of tables.

Common mistake Turning on bi-directional filters everywhere to 'fix' visuals — it causes ambiguity and slow reports.

Interviewer may ask next Why do you need a separate Date table? (Time-intelligence functions like TOTALYTD need a proper, continuous date table.)

19 Power Query vs DAX — what goes where?

Power BI Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

Knowing where cleaning should happen.

MODEL ANSWER

- Power Query (M): get and clean data before it loads — remove columns, fix types, split, merge, unpivot.
- DAX: calculations on the loaded model — measures, KPIs, time intelligence.
- Rule: shape and clean in Power Query; analyse with DAX. Each step is recorded and re-runs on refresh.

Common mistake Cleaning data with lots of DAX calculated columns that Power Query could have handled once.

Interviewer may ask next Merge vs Append in Power Query? (Merge = join columns on a key; Append = stack rows.)

20 Which chart would you use for what? How do you design a dashboard?

Visualisation Easy

WHAT THE INTERVIEWER IS CHECKING

Clear communication, not decoration.

MODEL ANSWER

- Trend over time → line chart. Compare categories → bar chart (sorted). Part of a whole → stacked bar or, for 2–4 parts, a donut.
- Relationship between two numbers → scatter. Distribution → histogram or box plot. Single KPI → card.
- Dashboard: KPIs at the top, trends in the middle, details/filters below. One question per page, consistent colours.

Common mistake Pie charts with 10 slices, 3D effects, or a dashboard with 15 visuals and no clear story.

Interviewer may ask next Your manager wants to see why sales fell last month. What would you put on the page?

BEFORE YOUR INTERVIEW

Revision checklist

Tick a question only when you can answer it out loud in under two minutes and give one real example.

- [ ] 01 VLOOKUP vs INDEX-MATCH vs XLOOKUP — which do you use?
- [ ] 02 Total sales for Bengaluru Electronics only. Which formula?
- [ ] 03 What is a pivot table and when would you use it?
- [ ] 04 What's the difference between A1, A1, $A1 and A$1?
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- [ ] 19 Power Query vs DAX — what goes where?
- [ ] 20 Which chart would you use for what? How do you design a dashboard?

Think out loud

Say your approach before you write anything. Interviewers score your reasoning, not just the final answer.

Connect it to the business

End answers with what the number means: “so we should focus on Bengaluru”, “so the model is safe to launch”.

Know your own projects

Expect “where did you use this?” after almost every question. Keep one project story ready per topic.

Say what you'd check

Mention nulls, duplicates, leakage or edge cases before being asked — it signals real experience.

Prepared the questions?
Now land the interview.

FirstOffer lists fresh fresher jobs, internships and off-campus drives every day — with direct HR emails, Google Forms and official apply links. No middlemen.

firstoffer.online

Daily job alerts on our WhatsApp Channel · Questions vary by company and role; understand the concepts, don't just memorise answers.